

The History of Polish Literature



CZESŁAW MIŁOSZ

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The voice of the poet himself, murmuring, hardly audible, is not similar to anything heard in Western poetry, and since he was exploiting hidden sonorities proper to one language only, he is untranslatable. His lyrics can be likened to chamber music made poignant by the counterpoint of dark philosophical and metaphysical problems. His volumes of verse where sensual dreams and poetic myths express his anxieties—*a day like everyday* (*dzień jak codzień*, 1930), *a ballad from beyond* (*ballada z tamtej strony*, 1932), *in lightning* (*w błyskawicy*, 1934), *nothing more* (*nic więcej*, 1936), *a human note* (*nota człowieka*, 1939)—can be included in the “catastrophist” trend. (Czechowicz did not use capital letters or punctuation.) His foreboding of a universal conflagration and of his own imminent death lent a peculiar light to his bucolic landscapes. He was killed by a bomb in his native Lublin at the age of only thirty-six.

“Zagary” In 1931, a group of students at the University of Wilno founded a little review whose name, *Żagary*, they borrowed from the Lithuanian for “brushwood,” or, in a more local meaning, for dry twigs half charred in fire but still glowing. Their group best exemplified all the contradictory strivings that were propelling the young generation beyond accepted artistic forms. Because of their dark visions in which the political was translated into the cosmic by means of a new kind of symbolism, they were soon recognized as the instigators of a “school of catastrophists.” Basically antiaesthetic, they hesitated between their sympathies for Marxism and their metaphysical frame of reference. They declared their independence from both “Skamander” and the First Vanguard, confining themselves to no single poetics. In the sphere of social responsibility, their attitude was ambivalent, oscillating between commitments of one sort or another and the defense of their freedom as poets who reserved the right to reject commitment if it threatened their artistic liberty.

One of the three original founders of the group, Teodor Bujnicki (1907–1944), was killed during the war by a Right-Wing underground organization and left no important work. Jerzy Zagórski (1907–) wrote significant poems before 1939. They are contained in the volumes *A Blade of a Bridge* (*Ostrze mostu*, 1933), *Expeditions* (*Wyprawy*, 1937), and particularly in his *Coming of the Enemy* (*Przyjście wroga*, 1934), with the subtitle *A Poem–Fairy Tale*. This captivating chaos of fragments in prose, surrealist songs, and biblical verses is used to convey an anticipated immensity of the disaster awaiting the earth. Armies moving from the Caucasus to the North Pole, the birth of a man-monster who perhaps is Antichrist, Asiatic steppes exploding with human masses, make for one of the weirdest sets of symbols in modern poetry, the key to which was not provided by the author. During the war, Zagórski

lived in Warsaw, editing underground publications—among which was an anthology of anti-Nazi poems. After the war he remained active as a poet and a translator of poetry, associating himself with Roman Catholic intellectual circles.

The youngest of the founders, Czesław Miłosz (1911–) is the author of this book, and he feels embarrassed to characterize his contribution. Born in the heartland of Lithuania, son of a civil engineer whose professional wanderings brought the family to Siberia and the banks of the Volga, he received his master's degree in law from the University of Wilno. His first slim volume of poetry, *A Poem on Time Frozen* (*Poemat o czasie zastygłym*, 1933), was spoiled by social ratiocinations; but the next, *Three Winters* (*Trzy zimy*, 1936), is considered by literary historian and critic Kazimierz Wyka the most representative work of "catastrophism." Its rush of symbols, set unexpectedly into lines with a classicist ring, alludes to calamities of cosmic amplitude. Critics have tended to see a myth of the Earth, a protective deity ever renewing herself, as the core of Miłosz's poetry, or have been calling him the only true pantheist in Polish poetry. It is not certain whether this is true, since Christian elements are also strong. There is no doubt, however, that his poetry is permeated with the nature of his native Lithuania. During the war, Miłosz lived in Warsaw, where he edited a clandestine anthology of anti-Nazi poems. His poetic work, collected in a volume called *Rescue* (*Ocalenie*, 1945), and published as one of the first books in postwar Poland, marked a new approach to historical tragedy and, together with the volumes of Ważyk, Jastrun, and Przyboś, left its stamp upon the development of Polish poetry in the next two decades.

As for other members of the "Żagary" group, Jerzy Putrament (1910–) published two volumes before the war, *Yesterday the Return* (*Wczoraj powrót*, 1935) and *Forest Road* (*Droga leśna*, 1938), an interesting cross between his sensitivity to the landscape of his native region south of Wilno and his Marxist, revolutionary commitment. However, except for a few war poems published after his return from the Soviet Union as an officer of the Polish Communist Army, he developed as a writer of less than first-rate fiction. Aleksander Rymkiewicz (1913–), intimately bound, as were all of his colleagues, to a northern nature of forests, lakes, and marshes, produced before the war quite an extraordinary poem, "The Pathfinder" ("Tropiciel," 1936), a fairy tale about an eerie polar expedition that, in fact, translates the same fears common to the whole group into images of snow, ice, and frost. After the war, Rymkiewicz, one of the numerous Poles who had to migrate from Wilno, found a substitute homeland in the forests of East Prussia taken over by Poland.